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Graded Twice, Charged Once

Paired Independent Assessment of End-of-Lease Condition Reports Across 192 Vacating Tenancies

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The problem

End-of-lease condition reports are treated as an objective record: one tick per line item, a schedule of deductions computed from the result. The sums are itemised to the dollar. Whether two assessors walking the same emptied property record the same thing has not been established.

Research questions

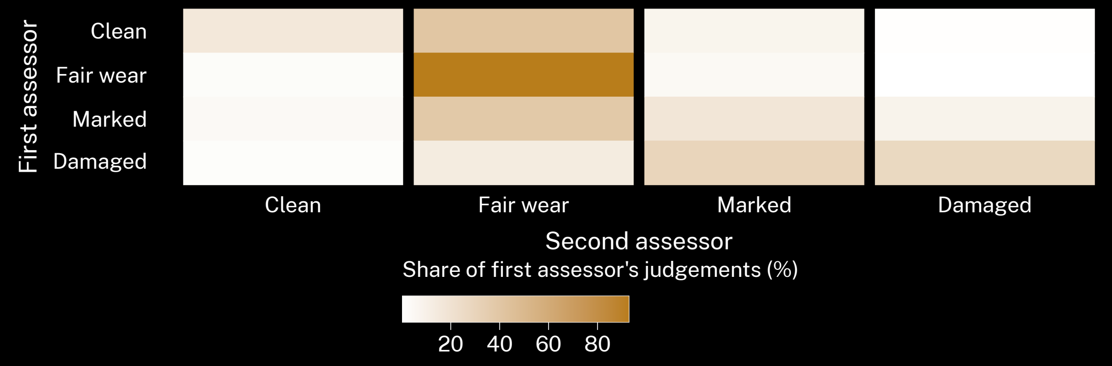
- How far do independent assessors agree on the standard 22-item vacate condition report?
- Does agreement hold on the line items carrying the largest scheduled deductions?
- Does raw agreement — the figure reported upward — track agreement beyond chance?

Study design

- 192 vacating tenancies · two assessors per property, independent and blind to each other · 22 line items · four-point condition scale · paired walk-throughs within 48 hours.
- Cohen's κ pooled and per item; prevalence-adjusted bias-adjusted κ reported alongside.
- Assessor pairings rotated across the portfolio; the deduction schedule withheld from both assessors until submission.

What we found

Raw agreement across 4,224 paired judgements is 85.0%. Pooled κ is 0.26, and falls to 0.11 across the six line items — walls, carpet, window furnishings, oven, grout, garden — that carry the largest scheduled deductions.



Row-normalised paired grades, 192 vacating tenancies, October 2025 to May 2026. Where the first assessor records Fair wear the second agrees 92.9% of the time; where the first records Clean, 19.4%. Agreement is highest on the one grade attracting no deduction.

Interpretation & takeaways

High raw agreement alongside low chance-corrected agreement is the signature of a skewed marginal: 89% of judgements land on Fair wear, so matching by chance is cheap. Agreement is weakest precisely where the schedule attaches money. Prevalence-adjusted bias-adjusted κ is 0.70 — the statistic the schedule's own guidance recommends. Next: a revised form carrying two further condition categories, and assessor training scored against raw agreement.

Selected references

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3. Feinstein, A. R., & Cicchetti, D. V. (1990). High agreement but low kappa: I. The problems of two paradoxes. *Journal of Clinical Epidemiology*, 43(6), 543–549. doi:10.1016/0895-4356(90)90158-L
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5. Okafor, D., & Solberg, T. (2026). Same Flip, Six Readings: What Actually Trips the Library Silent Floor's Noise Light Red. School of Continuous Improvement, Slop University. doi:10.5555/slop.bmm3u3

Property and tenancy identifiers removed before coding; assessors consented to paired allocation and were not told which walk-throughs were paired. doi:10.5555/slop.fhlpyv

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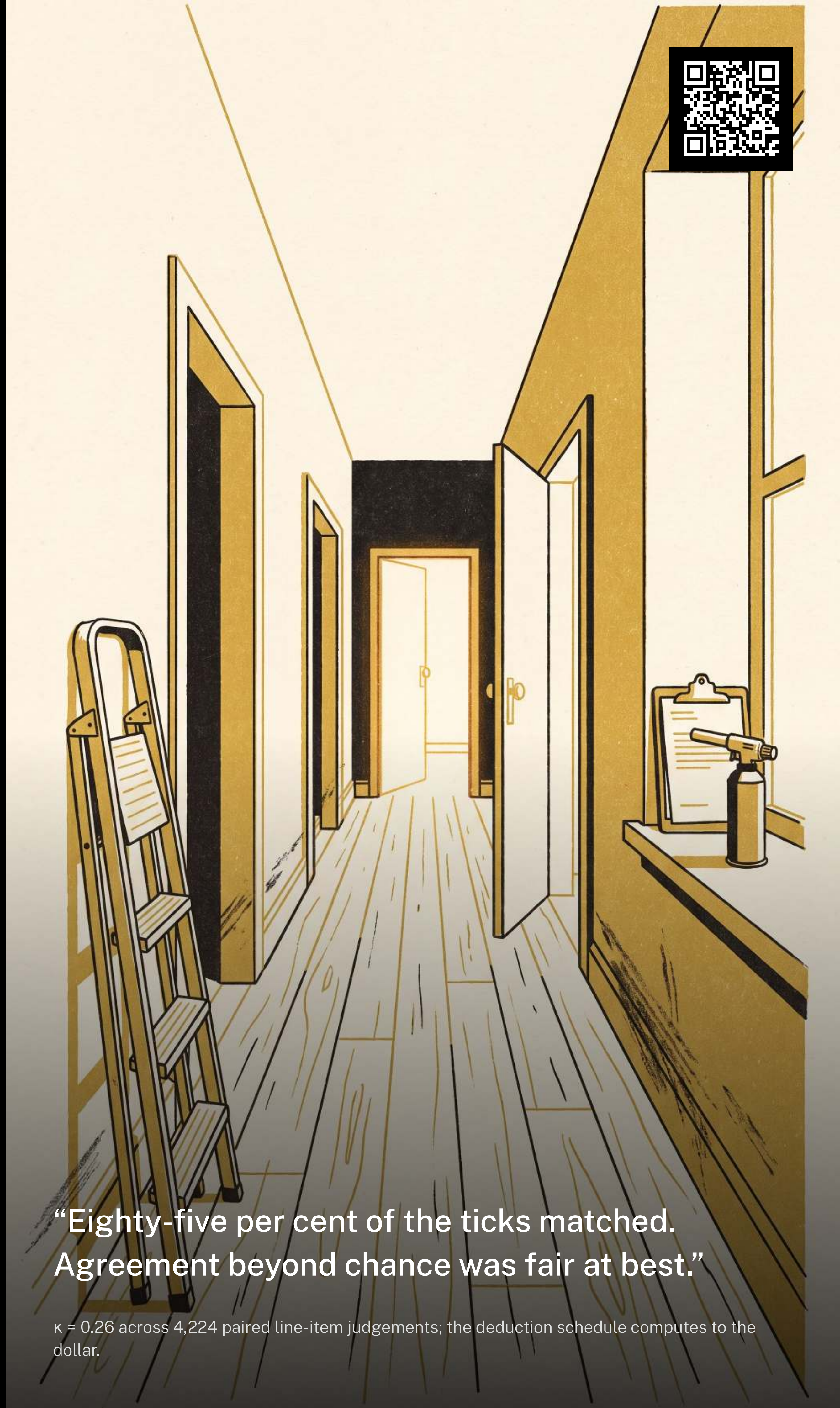

"Eighty-five per cent of the ticks matched. Agreement beyond chance was fair at best."

κ = 0.26 across 4,224 paired line-item judgements; the deduction schedule computes to the dollar.

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